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THE WAVE State unit chief C.P. Joshi, Raje and Nadda at the 'Nahin Sahega Rajasthan Abhiyan' launch in Jaipur, Jul. 16

RAJASTHAN/BJP

A QUESTION OF LEADERSHIP

specific caste geographies—Abu Road and Bhilwara for a Gujjar-tribal connect, for instance, or Dausa for a Meena outreach. The proposed July 27 rally in Sikar will reinforce the pattern, rekindling the Rajput and Jat base. The organisational shape too is caste-governed: former royalty and general secretary Diya Kumari is the Rajput face, and among the vice-presidents are a saffron-clad Nath mahant in Baba Balak Nath, a Gujjar in Sukhbir Singh Jaunapuria, a Jat in C.R. Chaudhary and a Sikh in Ajay Pal Singh. In Bikaner, the PM pulled no punches while tearing into Team Gehlot, pouncing on even the minutest angularity. The allegations of rampant bribery were plum pickings. "Even their ministers and MLAs are accusing each other of eating their share of commissions, transfers and postings," Modi said. The PM reminded people how the Congress reneged on its 2018 poll promise of waiving farmers' loans in 10 days, even as he pulled up the state government for failing to properly execute central schemes such as the Jal Jeevan Mission (JJM)—where the state is a laggard—and for the leakage of question papers for recruitment exams. The poor price of millets in Rajasthan compared with neighbouring Haryana also came in for a derisive mention.

IF THE BJP DOES DECIDE TO REPEAT ITS STATE-WIDE YATRAS OF 2003 AND 2013, WHO WILL LEAD IT? THE QUESTION LINGERS

Religion has inevitably entered the narrative too. At the Udaipur rally on June 30, Shah and former CM Vasundhara Raje brought up the killing of tailor Kanhaiya Lal by two Muslim fanatics in that town last year. But Modi turned on its head Gehlot's barb on the BJP's "divisive agenda", accusing him of appeasement politics while also referencing Rajasthan's rising crime graph. Joining the rhetorical contest, Gehlot and state Congress chief Govind Singh Dotasra accused the Centre of failing to negotiate a settlement with public sector banks on loans, something it does for defaulting industrialists. Defending the low JJM score, Dotasra said the "very low coverage" originally laid out for Rajasthan compared to other states was to blame rather than tardy implementation. The duo also question Modi's silence over the Eastern Rajasthan Canal, which the Rajasthan CM wants declared a national project. Dotasra's cruellest cut was reserved for the BJP as a party. Calling Nadda's July 16 rally a "flop", he could not resist the jibe that even BJP workers had stopped going to their rallies.

Rajasthan's entrenched pattern of voting out incumbents does hand the BJP an advantage, but questions still linger. Will it be taking out a state-wide yatra to whip up anti-incumbency, as it did in 2003 and 2013? There's very little time left now. If a yatra is planned, who will lead it? A collective pantheon, or will Raje finally get pride of place? Somehow, every discussion on the BJP boils down to her. Shah did intervene to have her speak ahead of him in Udaipur, and requested her to accompany him in his car when leader of the opposition Rajendra Singh Rathore omitted calling her. Modi, though, did not interact with anyone on stage, to avoid any signalling. Will Raje head the election committee, the only significant post left? Her rallies in the past two years, often camouflaged as personal events, have overshadowed even top-billed BJP shows—Kota on July 2 was no different. The party's second-rung leadership, reluctant to let Raje take the lead, say they will win comfortably without her. Given the ambivalence, contrasted with the Congress settling its own leadership tussle in Gehlot's favour, the cadre is not so sure. ■